

RELIGION

What is Religion?

Religion is a system of beliefs, practices, values, and rituals through which people relate to what they consider sacred or divine. It often explains life's meaning, moral rules, the origin of the world, and how humans should live.

Definition of Traditional Religion

Traditional religion refers to the indigenous belief systems that originated within particular communities or cultures and were passed down from generation to generation through oral tradition, customs, and rituals. These religions are closely connected to ancestors, nature, and community life.

(Examples include African Traditional Religion, Native American religions, and Aboriginal belief systems.)

Words Associated with Traditional Religion

Ancestors

Deity

Supreme Being

Spirits

Shrine

Sacrifice

Ritual

Worship

Priest

Priestess

Divination

Oracle

Totem

Taboo

Festival

Incantation

Offering

Libation

Myth

Sacred

Community

Initiation

Medicine man

Sacred objects

Belief system

Nature

Moral laws

Afterlife

Cleansing

Protection

Meaning of Ten of the Words Listed

Ancestors – Dead family members believed to guide and protect the living.

Supreme Being – The highest god, believed to be the creator of the universe.

Spirits – Supernatural beings believed to influence human life and nature.

Shrine – A sacred place where worship and rituals are performed.

Sacrifice – Offering animals, food, or items to gods or spirits.

Ritual – A set of traditional actions performed during worship or ceremonies.

Divination – The practice of seeking knowledge or guidance from spiritual sources.

Taboo – An action forbidden by religious or cultural laws.

Libation – The pouring of drink as an offering to ancestors or spirits.

Initiation – A ceremony marking entry into a new stage of life or group.

Class Exercises and Answers

Exercise 1: Fill in the Blanks

- a. A sacred place of worship is called a _____.
- b. The pouring of drink to honor ancestors is known as _____.
- c. The highest god in traditional religion is the _____.

Book References on Traditional Religion

Mbiti, J. S. African Religions and Philosophy